and power subsidies to MSMEs under the Atmanirbhar Gujarat scheme. This had industry excited after a long time. Now those files need to move—facilitating MSMEs to set up shop or expand can lead to local job creation. Foxconn's semiconductor plant in Dholera and Tata Airbus's facility near Vadodara too present clear opportunities. "Honestly, industry does not really care if there is a super-CM, whether the decisions are taken here or in Delhi, as long as the files move at the requisite pace," says a Surat-based businessman.

Over 1.5 million government employees had launched protests against contractual engagement and pay structures, with job-seekers not far behind. Over 1 million government jobs are vacant—a dozen-plus paper leaks in the past two years before entrance exams for these positions had kicked up a lot

"INDUSTRY DOESN'T REALLY CARE IF DECISIONS ARE TAKEN IN NEW DELHI, AS LONG AS THE FILES MOVE"

of dust. Decisive action will need to be taken to fill up these posts before 2024.

Several other tricky issues stayed on the backburner in the heat of election, and they will come to a head soon. The genesis of the EWS quota, cleared by the Supreme Court recently, was the Patidar agitation of 2015, but implementation won't be easy. Plus, the Gujarat High Court is not budging on the stray cattle issue, and the government is hard-pressed to comply with its order for a clean-up. Other pet BJP themes where it will need to keep the faithful happy: the UCC (the approval for forming a panel for the UCC was given just before the polls), the 'anti-love jihad law', and the Land Grabbing (Prohibition) Act. Whether purely governance issues or ideological ones for the gallery, the state government has to do some heavy lifting in the months to come. ■

HIMACHAL

VERTICAL LIMIT

By Rajiv Phull

All are not destined to be born with a silver spoon in their mouth. But a few commoners reach uncommon heights just by virtue of their persistence. It took a four-decade trek for Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, son of a state transport bus driver, to arrive at the summit of Himachal Pradesh's politics. But like all those who walk in the mountains, the new chief minister will likely find that even taller peaks loom ahead of him. More daunting than he may have imagined when he successfully fought off a stiff challenge to the post from PCC president Pratibha Singh, Mandi MP and widow of former CM Virbhadra Singh.

Anti-incumbency is sometimes seen as an abstract sense of disenchantment, but in Himachal there were concrete policy issues at stake. The demand for the Old Pension Scheme to be restored was chief among them. As the government swung into action mode right after the swearing-in, the fiscal challenge it poses is going to test its nerve. The number of employees recruited after April 2004 and covered under the New Pension Scheme (NPS) is estimated at over 130,000. Outgoing CM Jairam Thakur had said last year, in response to an assembly question, that the state would have to bear a one-time burden of Rs 2,000 crore, and Rs 500 crore per annum subsequently, to restore the OPS. (The state budget for 2022-23 was Rs 51,365 crore.) The Sukhu government has initiated the process of collecting data regarding the exact number of employees recruited under the NPS, and the financial implications thereof. Other states that wish to restore the OPS will be watching with interest.



UTTAR PRADESH

UNITED THEY STAND



PREM SINGH/UNI

FAMILY UNIT Newly-elected SP MP Dimple Yadav arrives at Parliament House with husband Akhilesh and other SP leaders to take oath of office